


**BALLOT BACKLASH**
Youth Congress workers protesting against alleged electoral manipulation, Bikaner, Sept. 18, 2025

PTI

**Q. Is Rahul Gandhi's 'vote chori' allegation an issue for voters?**

| | |
|---|---|
| Yes, it matters a lot | 40 |
| Yes, to some extent | 14 |
| No, it does not matter | 27 |
| No, there are other more pressing issues | 10 |

Rest, don't know/ can't say

**With a majority saying "it matters", claims of electoral manipulation register as a genuine voter concern, not just partisan noise**

*All figures in % and rounded off*

concerns over unemployment have dropped in this MOTN. "One is an X factor—which is that women are now receiving massive amounts of dole from both the Centre and the state, easing the pressure on finding employment. The other is that with inflation falling considerably in recent months, the pressure to upgrade to better-paying jobs may have lessened." What could have aided the process is the increase in the personal income tax-free limit from Rs 7 lakh to Rs 12 lakh in Budget 2025. Overall, though, issues pertaining to the economy continue to dominate the failure list, accounting for 45 per cent.

**DOLES TO WOMEN, LOW INFLATION AND THE INCREASE IN THE PERSONAL INCOME TAX-FREE LIMIT PERHAPS ACCOUNT FOR THE LOWERING IN THE CONCERN OVER LACK OF EMPLOYMENT**

That the economy needs to remain the Modi government's top priority despite the favourable electoral ratings comes through in other findings of the MOTN poll. Lack of jobs, inflation, poverty, farm distress and lack of infrastructure continue to be the most important issues for the electorate. What's encouraging for the Modi government is that 48.8 per cent rate its handling of the economy as 'outstanding' to 'good'. But the optimism about the economy improving in the next six months remains modest, with only 35.8 per cent endorsing that opinion. On whether economic growth has been inclusive, a majority believe only the rich and, to some extent, the middle class have benefited. That perception persists when it comes to the government's economic policies, with a majority stating it favours big business to the detriment of micro and small entrepreneurs. As worrying is the